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The House pushed through a last-minute flurry of legislation Wednesday, including a \$636 billion Pentagon funding bill, a short-term rise in the nation's debt limit, and an extension of unemployment and health benefits for millions of jobless Americans. But Democrats put off until next year some of the thorniest political issues facing the chamber. While the House passed on party lines a largely symbolic \$150 billion job-creation bill, that legislation has virtually no chance of seeing action in the Senate this year and was a reflection of Democrats' belief that addressing the nation's unemployment crisis will have to be their top priority when they return to business in January. Likewise,

the vote to temporarily raise the debt limit by \$290 billion allowed House leaders to kick down the road tougher questions about deficit spending that have become a focal point for Republican attacks. As the Senate struggled to bring the debate over health care to a close and turned temporarily to consideration of the must-pass Pentagon bill, the House effectively finished its business for the year. Speaker Nancy Pelosi (D-Calif.) said she told her colleagues at a morning gathering that the legislative decks were almost cleared so Democrats could focus on the economy next year to gear up for the 2010 midterm elections. Pelosi said she does not think "there's any risk" that Democrats

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